PLAYMAKER

OPEN YOUR EYES

"Every possession asks one question: what is the best shot you can create before the clock runs out? Read the floor. Find the mismatch. Make the extra pass."

2 PLAYERS · 12+ AGE · 30–60 MINUTES

DESIGN: SHAUN BARTLETT

Aim of the game

Two players, two possessions. Each player attacks once and defends once.

You have 12 seconds to build the best shot you can. Shots are never rolled: a shot scores what it was worth. The higher score wins.

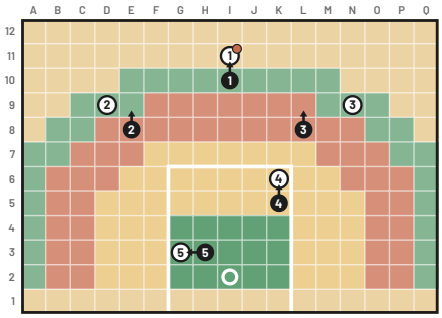
So reading the floor beats luck. Find the open player, the mismatch, the right moment to shoot.

In the box

Component	What it's for
Court board	Where you play. It also shows shot zones, the shot clock and key rules.
2 trackers	One for offence, one for defence. **Every action's rules are printed here.**
75 player cards	Offence ratings on the front, defence on the back.
10 player pieces	5 white O (screen T on the back), 5 black X with an arrow.
12 action tokens	6 white, 6 black. One token is one action.
4 lock tokens	Mark a player who can't Move, Sprint or Dribble this phase.
Ball and d20	The ball sits on the ball carrier.
Shot clock marker	Counts down the 12 seconds.
Score book	For scores, fouls and turnovers.
First-game guides and playbook	Optional. Worked examples and plays to try.

Setup

1. Each player takes 5 player cards, one per position. For your first game, use a prescribed team.
2. Roll the d20. The higher roll attacks first and sits on the **left**, with the offence tracker.
3. Put the shot clock marker on **12**.
4. The offence places its 5 O pieces anywhere. The ball goes on a player standing on plain wood beyond the three-point tiles.
5. The defence places its 5 X pieces on empty squares. Point each arrow any way you like.
6. Each player puts their 6 action tokens in their tracker's action pool.



A typical start. Squares are named by column and row, like I11.

The shot

Every shot is worth:

Shot value

points × (rating − contest)

Points: 2 or 3, from the tile the shooter stands on.
Rating: the shooter's card rating for that shot.
Contest: an adjacent defender's rating against it (the defence picks who).

Example: a shooter rated 13 from mid-range, contested by a 4: 2 × (13 − 4) = **18**.

Reading the court

The coloured tiles show the points for a shot from that square.

2	Layup, dunk, post move
3	Three-pointer
2	Mid-range, floater
2	Long two
–	Plain wood: no shot

Rolling

Roll the d20. You **succeed** on **equal to or under** your rating minus theirs. Pass 15 v Intercept 7: 8 or less.

Playing a possession

The possession is played in **phases** of 2 seconds. Repeat these steps until someone shoots or the clock runs out.

1. Take turns

The offence goes first. Then the teams take turns. On your turn, take **1 or 2 actions**.

To take an action, move an action token from your pool into the player's slot on your tracker. Your tracker explains each action.

Actions below the black bar **end your turn**. Play them last. Each team gets **one Pause** (defence) or **one Hesitate** (offence) a phase.

2. End the phase

The phase ends when:

- the offence plays its last token. The defence gets one more turn first.
- the defence plays its last token. It ends at once.
- a shot is taken.

3. Reset

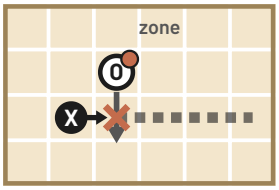
Put all action tokens back in the pools. Remove lock tokens. Move the shot clock down 2. Players stay where they are.

If the clock reaches **0** before a shot: **turnover, –5**, and the ball carrier takes a forced shot from where the pieces stand, contested as normal. Plain wood, or a value below 0, scores 0.

Defender arrows

Each X piece points an arrow. **Next to** always includes diagonals.

A defender's **zone** is the squares along his arrow that one movement could reach. It stops at the first player in the way, and shrinks once he has used his Move.



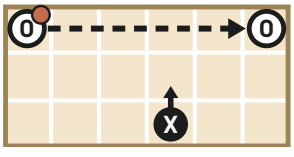
The ball carrier can't drive through the zone of a defender next to him.

- **Drives**: the ball carrier may step into the zone of a defender next to him, but not through it, unless he wins a Dribble.
- **Arrow on the ball carrier**: the defender can Steal, and contests cleanly.

Passes and intercepts

A pass fixes a line from passer to receiver. The defence answers with its **first action**, or the pass lands.

- **Through you**: the line passes through your square's centre. Intercept, whatever your facing.
- **Jump the lane**: one straight Move, Quick Step or Sprint along your arrow, keeping your facing, whose path touches or crosses the line. Then Intercept. That's your whole turn.
- **Next to the passer**: no intercept on any square around him. Steal instead.



Jump the lane: X steps straight along his arrow onto the pass.

Roll ≤ Pass – Intercept. A miss leaves him on the line, Move used.

Screens

Any player except the ball carrier. A Screen is the turn's first action, or its second straight after that player's own Move, and it ends the turn. It lasts until the screener moves, a Challenge beats it, or the phase ends.

Shooting

Declare a Shot. The defence takes one last turn to react. Then one adjacent defender contests: the defence picks who.

Arrow off the shooter: he contests with a foul roll. Further from the rim than the shooter: at **–3**.

Your tracker explains every action: **when**, the **roll** and the **result**.

Scoring

What happened	Score
Intercept or steal	–5 and lose 2 seconds; play on. A stolen shot is cancelled. Last phase: scores 0
First foul on a steal	+5, play on
Second foul on a steal	Free throws, possession ends
Foul on a shot	Free throws or the open shot, whichever is higher; possession ends
Shot clock hits 0	Forced shot as they stand, –5

Free throws score 2 × the shooter's FT rating, or 3 × on a three.

Winning

After the first possession, swap seats and trackers, flip every player card, and set up again.

After both possessions, the **higher score wins**. Tied? Each player rolls for their final shot: d20 ≤ rating – contest. A make beats a miss.